

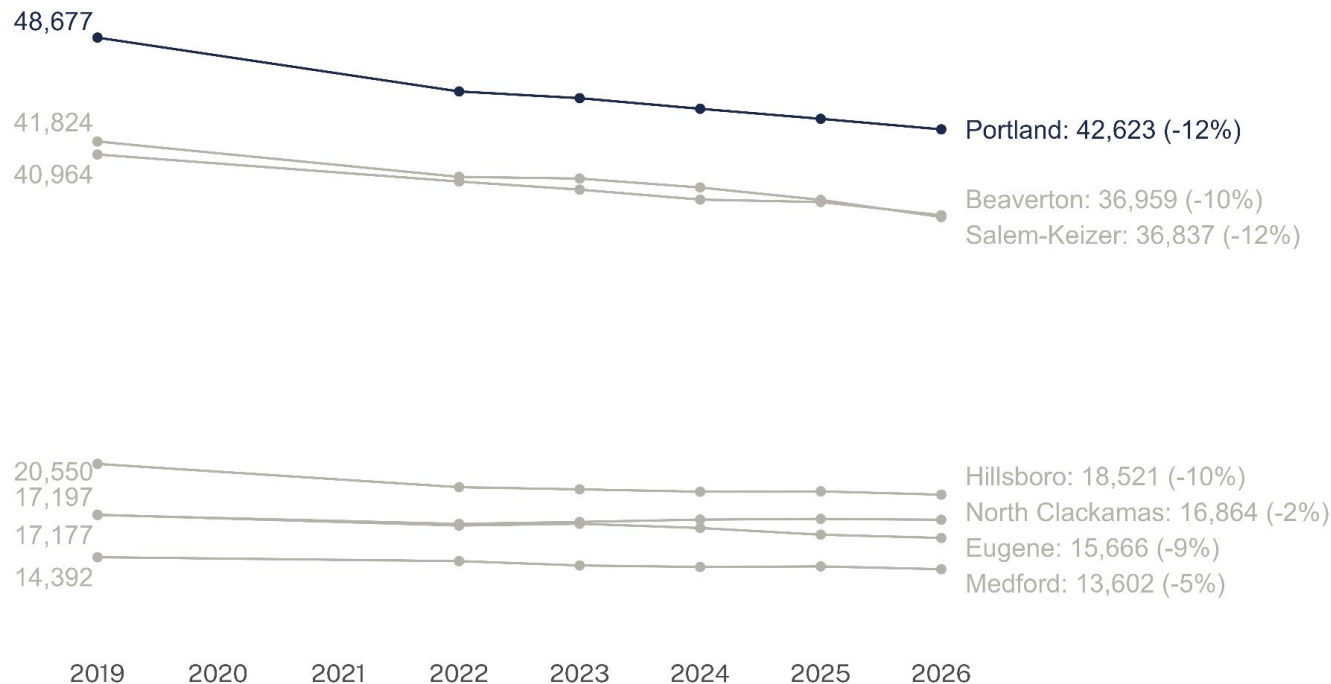
PPS Rightsizing: What the Evidence Shows

September 2026

What is the context?

PPS enrollment is down sharply, in line with its peers

Fall Enrollment Change since 2019



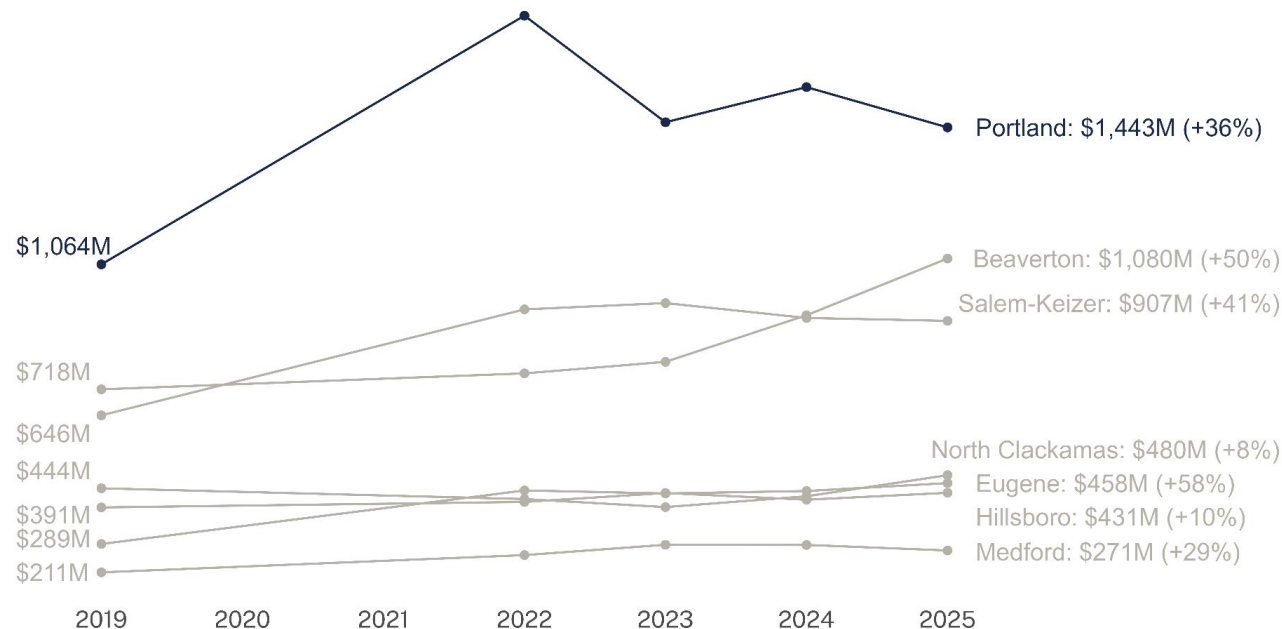
School enrollment has declined every year since the COVID pandemic across nearly every large district in the state.

Portland's decline is large, but comparable to Beaverton and Salem-Keizer.

Source: Oregon Dept. of Education

PPS' Spending Has Grown since the Pandemic, along with its peers

Overall Expenditures Change Since 2019



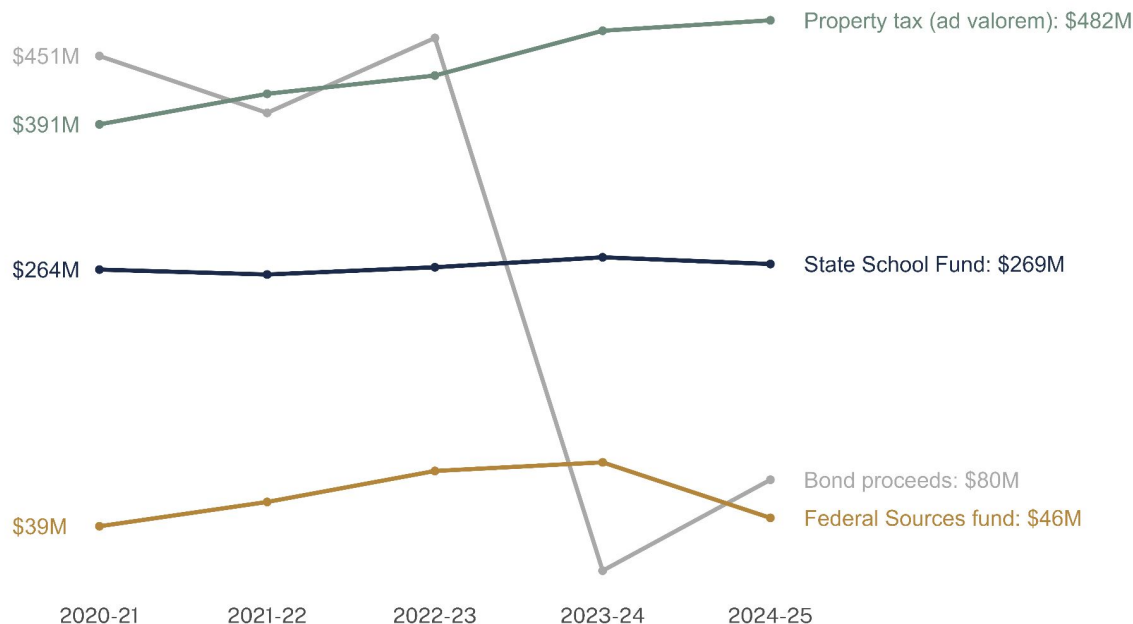
Source: Actual Reported Expenditures from Oregon Dept. of Education

Portland has the state's largest school budget, which has grown 36% since 2019.

Portland's budget growth is smaller in percentage terms than the next two largest districts.

What's the problem?

PPS Revenues Over Time



Source: Selected major categories of reported revenues from Oregon Dept. of Education

Portland's major increases in revenue largely came from recent construction and capital improvement bonds as well as federal COVID relief.

Inflation has increased fixed costs, and has put upward pressure on salaries to keep pace. However, the actual useable revenue sources have not changed substantially.

So we should close schools?

Closing schools saves the district a little, but harms students and communities a lot.

[Research on Chicago school closures](#) found **students lost roughly 1.5 months of reading progress during the announcement year alone**, before any transition occurred.

[Philadelphia research](#) shows **receiving schools experience measurable achievement declines** for up to two years after absorbing displaced students, particularly when they exceed a ~10% concentration threshold.

Once holding costs, security, and maintenance on vacant buildings are factored in, **net savings typically fall below \$1M per building** — a modest return for significant community disruption ([source](#)). Moreover, [recent research from California](#) shows that district savings from school closures were offset by revenue losses from losing enrollment during the closures.

Vacant school buildings accelerate neighborhood disinvestment. research by [Brinig & Garnett](#) links closures to increased blight, crime, and erosion of the social cohesion that schools anchor in their communities.

[Long-term data from Milwaukee and Texas](#) show **students displaced by closures have lower graduation rates, lower college enrollment, and lower earnings into their mid-20s** when they don't land in meaningfully better schools.

Cautionary Tale: Southeast Guiding Coalition (SEGC)

PPS commissioned [an evaluation](#) of their SEGC work that redrew boundaries, feeder patterns and relocated schools in 2023.

SEGC schools **experienced larger enrollment declines** than non-SEGC schools, which was part of what led to more “balanced” enrollment. (p. 6)

SEGC-impacted schools experienced **a concentration of student need**, with larger populations of English learners and students with disabilities than projected after the project. (p. 6)

Although a stated goal of SEGC was to provide access to robust middle school experiences, **SEGC middle school outcomes were not transformed**. (p.43)

School **staff were broadly demoralized and left PPS at rates well above their peers** elsewhere in the district, with staff of color leaving at nearly double the rate of their counterparts (18% vs. 10%). (pp. 14, 17)

Cautionary Tale: Jefferson County, Colorado (“Jeffco”)

Jeffco did exactly what PPS is proposing, calling it "[Jeffco Thrives 2025](#)," framed around "fewer but more robustly-resourced schools." Their problems aren't solved:

- Despite saving \$12-20M/year and selling buildings, Jeffco announced a **\$60M budget gap for 2026-27** in Dec 2025, cutting 139 more positions (50 layoffs) and dipping into reserves. ([CPR News, Dec 2025](#))
- **One round wasn't enough:** beyond the original 16 schools, Jeffco closed two more K-8s in 2024, ended its high-school moratorium, and is now closing Jefferson Jr./Sr. High for 2026-27, with 18 schools still under 60% capacity (28 projected by 2027-28). ([Chalkbeat, Feb 2025](#))
- **Enrollment kept falling:** Jeffco lost 4,200+ more students (5%) after the closures. ([CPR News, Dec 2025](#))

Other districts avoided closures

San Francisco: proposed 13 elementary + 2 high schools for closure; the plan was halted entirely within weeks of public pushback, the superintendent resigned, and any closures were pushed to 2026-27 under a rebuilt process

Seattle: proposed closing 21 elementaries, ultimately closed zero for 2025-26; projected savings shrank from \$30M to \$5-6M once specific schools were named, and enrollment had already stabilized by the time the plan was withdrawn.

What is PPS Saying?

The 360-student threshold: what it is, and how it's being used

WHAT THE QEM ACTUALLY IS

360

Elementary

500

Middle

1,000

High

Three hypothetical "prototype schools," used only to estimate the statewide cost of a quality K-12 system. It is a funding-formula input, not an evaluation of any real school or district.

Importantly, the student threshold is ALSO paired with a staffing package:

- ☐ All-day kindergarten
- ☐ Class size average of 20
- ☐ 1 librarian per school
- ☐ 1 school nurse per school
- ☐ 1 PE and music specialist per school
- ☐ 1 Family Resource staffer per school
- ☐ Computers for students & staff

HOW PPS IS USING IT

15

elementary schools recommended for closure so every remaining elementary reaches 360 students

The plan takes the headcount half of the QEM's prototype and leaves the resourcing half undefined: PPS has not committed to funding a nurse, librarian, PE specialist, and music specialist at every consolidated school, the actual substance the QEM says "360" is supposed to buy.

"...the AIR report recommended increasing the number of prototype schools to better represent diverse student needs and district characteristics... the QEM remains a tool designed for statewide estimation."

— Quality Education Commission, 2026 report

Source: Oregon Quality Education Commission, 2022/2024/2026 Quality Education Model reports

Do you trust the narrative?

Date	March 2026	April 2026	September 2026
Impact	5-10 schools	5-12 schools	10-20 schools
Rationale	<i>Closing schools represents “the opportunity to optimize school communities and make sure our schools are well resourced, and that we’re able to provide things for all of our schools in a way that responds to the needs of the students.”</i> -Superintendent Armstrong	<i>“Our goal here is to make sure that all of our schools here in PPS are properly resourced”</i> -Board Chair Wang	<i>“officials said the goal is to equalize offerings across Portland.”</i> OPB Coverage of Board Meeting

Here's how to stay involved



PPS Community Advocacy

WhatsApp group

WhatsApp Group

<https://savepdxschools.org>